

ASIA-PACIFIC

From terrorism charges to cybersecurity laws, authoritarian regimes exploit legal tools to terrorise the press

In 21 of the 32 countries and territories assessed across the Asia-Pacific zone, the state of press freedom is classified as either "difficult" or "very serious." It is one of the most repressive regions in the world – and the situation continues to deteriorate. This is largely due to legal attacks against the press, notably abusive charges and draconian laws. More troubling still, the censorship and propaganda tactics developed by regional authoritarian regimes, China foremost among them, are now spreading far beyond their borders.

Flourish is disabled.

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The reach of authoritarian censorship

On paper, virtually every country in the region recognises press freedom. In practice, the principle is systematically violated. North Korea (179th out of 180 countries and territories in the Index) is the most extreme example: even though it is enshrined in the constitution, press freedom is entirely fictitious. The country remains one of the most sealed-off regimes on earth, where independent journalism is simply banned outright and only regime propaganda thrives.

In China (178th), the government has dramatically expanded its repressive toolkit in recent years, including a raft of national security laws that are regularly invoked to imprison journalists. With 121 media professionals currently behind bars, China is the world's largest jailer of journalists. Its model of information control is openly emulated by its neighbours: in Vietnam (174th) and Myanmar (166th), so-called "cybersecurity" laws, modelled on Beijing's legal framework, have become key instruments of online censorship.

In Afghanistan (175th), since the Taliban returned to power in August 2021, the regime has continued to implement a wide array of laws designed to control the country's image, suppress any scrutiny of its rule, and impose its propaganda.

The criminalisation of journalism, from India to the Philippines

Even in more democratic environments, legal frameworks are increasingly being weaponised to silence newsrooms. In India (157th), judicial harassment of independent media is intensifying, driven by the growing use of criminal statutes – defamation and national security laws among them – directly targeting journalists. In Pakistan (153rd), the press faces relentless waves of restrictions amid a fraught political climate in which authorities seek to control, and in some cases suppress, the dissemination of journalistic content.

In the Philippines (114th), terrorism charges have become the authorities' preferred method for silencing the press. The case of 27-year-old journalist Frenchie Mae Cumpio has become the defining symbol of this tactic, known as "red-tagging": held

Singapore (123rd), Malaysia (95th) and Thailand (92nd), journalists are routinely subjected to strategic lawsuits against public participation – abusive cases known as SLAPPs – typically brought by political or economic elites exploiting a legal framework that offers scant protection to the press.

Democratic models under strain

Even in established democracies, legal provisions can undermine press freedom. In Japan (62nd), the state secrecy law continues to have a chilling effect on journalism as there are no adequate protections for source confidentiality to counterbalance it, which breeds self-censorship. In South Korea (47th), government measures introduced to combat the spread of "false information" have drawn criticism from press freedom organisations, yet another example of the persistent tension between tackling disinformation and preserving the right to report.

No country in the region features in the top 20 of the World Press Freedom Index. New Zealand (22nd) remains the region's model for press freedom, despite slipping six places. Other Asia-Pacific democracies, such as Taiwan (28th), Timor-Leste (30th) and Australia (33rd), face real challenges to upholding the right to reliable information, yet continue to offer broadly protective environments. They stand as exceptions in a region where press freedom is being steadily eroded.